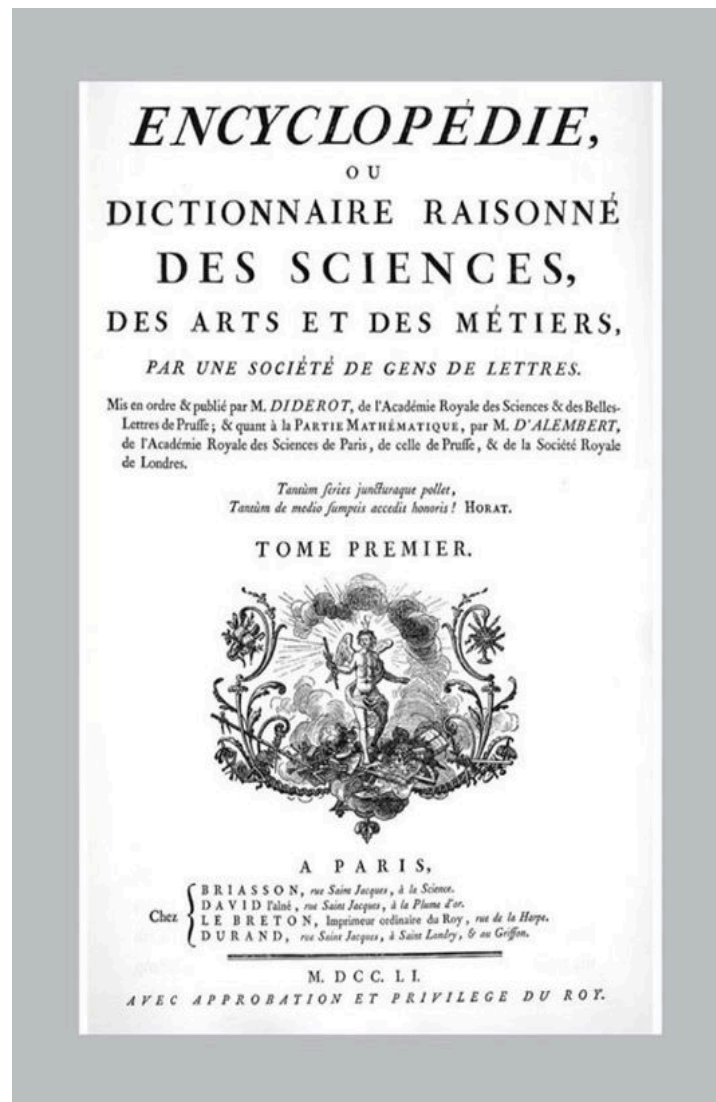


## Voltaire and the *encyclopédistes*



Political philosophy in the Age of Reason found a distinctive voice in 18th-century France. Influenced by the social contract theory of Hobbes and especially Locke, some French thinkers argued for more representative government to replace the existing rule of monarch and aristocracy. Foremost among them were the compilers of the massive *Encyclopédie*, Denis Diderot and Jean le Rond d'Alembert, who believed that education would enable people to participate in politics, instead of simply accepting conventional authorities. They were also influenced by the campaign of Voltaire (see [Freedom](#)) for separation of Church and state, freedom of

speech and religion, and a generally more tolerant society. Voltaire himself was a deist, believing that reason and observation confirmed the existence of God, but had little time for the established Church; Diderot and d'Alembert became outspoken atheist materialists, challenging any religious authority or divine right to rule. Their criticism of government fell just short of demand for a republic, but was in tune with a growing mood of the time.